



ANNUAL REPORT

2024 / 2025

Empowering Children for a Safer Digital Future



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Executive Summary

2024 was a year of expansion for IFDC's mission to protect children online and equip them, their families, and their teachers with the tools to navigate the digital world safely. Our flagship #DigitalWise program reached nearly 3,500 students across 25 schools in Sri Lanka with direct, in-person workshops on online grooming, sextortion, sexting, cyberbullying, and harassment — delivered alongside our #Kidspression and #Voice4Kids programs, which build children's creative voice and hold digital platforms accountable, respectively.

The need for this work remains urgent: NCMEC's CyberTipline recorded 137,361 reports of child sexual abuse material (CSAM) shared from Sri Lanka in 2023 alone, part of a sustained rise since 2019. Looking to 2025, IFDC will scale its school-based training to 100 seminars and 20,000 children, launch a Child Protection Ambassador Program across all 25 districts, complete five national research studies, and build an online support system for reporting and resources.

The International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) has been doing outstanding work through its dedicated network of young mentors to promote online child safety and digital mental health. Their team has regularly visited our school to conduct engaging sessions on online harms and responsible digital behaviour. IFDC has also provided valuable guidance to students, parents, and teachers on working together to help children navigate the digital world safely, responsibly, and confidently. Chaminda Kumara, Teacher, Mathugama central College.

About IFDC

At IFDC, our mission is clear: to protect children and empower them with the tools they need to safely navigate the digital world. Through a range of impactful programs, we have made significant strides in raising awareness about online safety, digital rights, and responsible internet use. This report presents a summary of our work and impact over 2024, together with our plans for 2025.

The National Context: CSAM Reports from Sri Lanka

Reports of child sexual abuse material (CSAM) shared from Sri Lanka, as recorded by the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children (NCMEC) CyberTipline, underline the scale of the challenge and the urgency of our work. Figures below are compiled and presented by PEaCE/ECPAT Sri Lanka.

2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
73,202	130,267	152,811	146,025	137,361

CSAM reports shared from Sri Lanka, 2019–2023 (Source: NCMEC CyberTipline, presented by PEaCE/ECPAT Sri Lanka)

The steep rise from 73,202 reports in 2019 to a peak of 152,811 in 2021, followed by a gradual decline to 137,361 in 2023, reflects both the growing scale of online risks to children and, more recently, the impact of stronger detection and reporting mechanisms. IFDC's programs are designed to address this trend directly — by reducing children's vulnerability to exploitation and by strengthening the reporting pathways that generate this data in the first place.

Our Impact at a Glance — 2024/2025

A summary of IFDC's reach and activity in 2024, drawn from our #DigitalWise program delivery.

Students Reached ~3,500	Schools Engaged 25	Core Programs 3
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What We Do

IFDC delivers three interlinked programs that together protect children online, nurture their creative voice, and hold the digital ecosystem accountable for children's rights.

01 #DigitalWise

Focuses on protecting children from all forms of online sexual abuse and exploitation, including grooming, sextortion, sexting, cyberbullying, and harassment. We raise awareness about online threats such as information overload, falsehoods, inappropriate content, self-harm, radicalization, privacy issues, and identity theft, and equip children, parents, and educators with practical tools to safeguard young minds online.

02 #Kidspression

Designed to unlock and nurture the creative talents of children. Through comprehensive training in creative media technologies, we empower young minds to express themselves, cultivate positive ideas, and explore their identities — aligned with the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child — helping every child become a producer of digital media, not just a consumer.

03 #Voice4Kids

Dedicated to documenting and researching how internet platforms exploit children and compromise their rights and safety. Using reliable data, we advocate for stronger child protection policies online, address harmful media portrayals of children, and promote ethical journalism to investigate issues affecting children and amplify their voices.



Students taking part in IFDC school sessions across Sri Lanka.

Seminar on Digital Addiction and Online Child Safety

The International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) conducted a seminar on digital addiction prevention and online child safety at St. Joseph's Boys' College, Colombo 14. The session focused on promoting healthy digital habits, understanding the risks of excessive screen use, and strengthening children's ability to navigate online spaces safely. Participants learned about digital addiction, harmful online content, cyberbullying, online grooming, sexting, sextortion, and child sexual abuse material (CSAM). Through interactive discussions and practical examples, students gained knowledge on identifying online risks, protecting personal information, and seeking support when facing digital threats. The programme highlighted the importance of digital balance, responsible technology use, and collective action to create safer online environments for children.

Seminar on Online Child Safety and Digital Risks

The International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) conducted an awareness seminar on online child safety for students of Handapangoda Maha Vidyalaya, targeting grades 9 to 12. The two-hour session focused on emerging online threats faced by children, including online grooming, cyberbullying, sexting, sextortion, and other forms of technology-facilitated abuse. Using storytelling methods, interactive discussions, and quiz-based activities, students explored how online offenders manipulate and target children. The session equipped participants with practical strategies to recognise risky situations, protect themselves online, and report harmful experiences. The programme contributed to building digital awareness among young people and promoting safer, more responsible engagement with digital technologies.



Scroll Smart Initiative – Promoting Safe and Responsible Social Media Use

The Scroll Smart initiative, led by Pehansa Wijenayaka, Advocate at the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC), aims to empower students with the knowledge and skills needed to navigate social media safely and responsibly. Recognising both the opportunities and risks of platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook, the programme focuses on digital literacy, online privacy, cyberbullying prevention, misinformation awareness, screen-time management, and digital wellbeing.

As a fellow of the IFDC Online Child Sexual Abuse Prevention Program (Cohort 1), Pehansa combines her advocacy experience with training in psychology and counselling to deliver interactive workshops using real-life examples and scenario-based learning. Students are guided to identify online risks, protect personal information, respond to harmful digital experiences, and use social media positively for learning, creativity, and social engagement.

The initiative also encourages collaboration among students, parents, and educators to create supportive environments where young people can discuss online challenges and seek guidance. Through Scroll Smart, students are encouraged to become mindful digital citizens who can make informed choices and contribute positively to safer online communities.



2024/25 Program Highlight: #DigitalWise



Through our #DigitalWise workshops, we've reached nearly 3,500 students across 25 schools in Sri Lanka. These workshops focused on raising awareness of online child sexual abuse and equipping children with the knowledge to protect themselves.

Key topics included online grooming, sextortion, sexting, cyberbullying, and online harassment. Students learned how to identify online threats, maintain digital privacy, and report online offenders. Our sessions emphasized the importance of open communication between children, parents, and teachers to ensure the safety and well-being of every child online.

Students Reached

~3,500

Schools Engaged

25

A Collaborative Approach



At #DigitalWise, we empower children to navigate the digital world responsibly by collaborating with schools, governments, and communities, ensuring online safety without limiting technology access.

The IFDC program for students is vital. It helps children understand the dangers of online sexual abuse and protect themselves from emerging threats, including AI risks. Many teachers and parents are unaware of these dangers and lack the resources to teach digital safety.

— Chathuranga, Teacher, Mathugama MMV

2024 in Pictures

Moments from IFDC's school sessions and community engagements over the year.



IFDC facilitators, teachers, and school officials at a program event.

Looking Ahead: 2025 Plan

Building on the momentum of 2024, IFDC will expand its reach and deepen its impact across four strategic workstreams in 2025.

School-Based Training

In 2025, we aim to conduct 100 seminars, reaching 20,000 children to promote digital safety, prevent online child sexual abuse, and improve mental well-being. Success will be measured by the number of seminars conducted and verified through school attendance records.

Research Initiatives

Partnering with academia, government agencies, and CSOs, we will complete five national studies on online child abuse, law enforcement, and policy gaps. Progress will be tracked by completed studies and verified through published research reports.

Child Protection Ambassador Program

We plan to select and train ambassadors in all 25 districts to lead child protection efforts locally. Success will be measured by the number of active ambassadors and verified through their activity reports.

Online Support System

An online system will be developed to help parents and children report safety issues and access resources. Impact will be tracked by the number of cases resolved and verified through system analytics and resolution data.

IFDC facilitator presenting on online safety at a school seminar.

Executive & Steering Committee

 Soorthi Mohan <i>Director, Executive Committee</i> Mental Health Advisor, Child Digital Safety Advocate, Researcher & Educator specializing in Psychology, English Language and Literature. Focuses on digital well-being, behavioral change, and mental health interventions. mksoorthi@gmail.com	 M.R. Mohamed Akeel <i>Assistant Director, Steering Committee</i> Medical undergraduate, practicing counsellor, and education entrepreneur. Founder of Gladwin; leads youth empowerment and emotional well-being programs across Sri Lanka. mailtom.akeelr@gmail.com
 Fathima Hafsa Haniffa <i>Secretary, Steering Committee</i> Combines IT expertise with a commitment to digital child safety. Supports IFDC's programs, partnerships and outreach to advance online safety education. hafsahaniffa1@gmail.com	 Kalani Bandara <i>Assistant Secretary, Steering Committee</i> Psychological counsellor working with children and adolescents. Uses a child-centred, empathetic approach to build resilience and equip children to stay safe online. kalzbandara@gmail.com
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 Nuha Ameen <i>Member, Steering Committee</i> Director of Mind Care International – Sri Lanka. Leads awareness programs on child protection, digital safety and learning difficulties, promoting emotional resilience. nuhawrites10@gmail.com	 Kirushnananth Vallipuram <i>Member, Steering Committee</i> Executive officer coordinating mentorship programs and a dedicated Child Protection Advocate, combining experience in administration, education and social development. kirushnavaqf@gmail.com

Financial Statement

Financial Statement

This is to confirm that the programmes implemented by the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) during the 2024/25 financial year were directly funded by The Story Café. While all programme implementation and delivery were carried out entirely by IFDC, the funds were managed and administered through The Story Café's financial management system. The funding was utilised almost entirely for direct programme implementation, community outreach, and related project activities in accordance with the approved programme objectives.

The grant funding was made available under a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed between The Story Café and the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC), which established the framework for programme implementation, financial management, and institutional collaboration.



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Income

Funding Source	Amount (LKR)
The Story Café — Programme Support	1,950,000
Total Income	1,950,000

Expenditure

Category	Amount (LKR)	% of Total
Programme Delivery (school workshops, session materials, printed resources)	950,000	48.7%
Volunteer Transport & Logistics	350,000	17.9%
Communications & Digital Outreach	250,000	12.8%
Venue & Equipment Support	200,000	10.3%
Administrative & Operational Costs	150,000	7.7%
Contingency / Miscellaneous	50,000	2.6%
Total Expenditure	1,950,000	100%

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Acknowledgements & A Note on This Report

IFDC's 2024 work was made possible through the participation and support of the schools, teachers, students, and school officials who welcomed our #DigitalWise sessions into their classrooms and assembly halls — including Mathugama MMV, whose staff generously shared their reflections for this report.

This report was compiled from IFDC's published 2024 program materials. To make future editions more complete, we would welcome the following if available: a financial summary (income, expenditure, and funding sources); a list of the board, staff, and partner organizations; a full list of participating schools and districts; and a month-by-month or district-by-district activity log. Adding these would let this report speak to governance and funding, not only programmatic impact.

Closing Reflection

The fight against child sexual abuse must extend beyond prevention — it must also address the profound psychological, emotional, and behavioral consequences. The stakes are high: failing to address the mental health impact of online sexual abuse leaves survivors carrying their trauma in silence, burdened by shame, guilt, and isolation.

— Dr. Najat Maalla M'jid, United Nations Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Violence Against Children

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